

- You will have a lower price point than your peers, despite the fact that you have similar income, credit, and savings.
- You are comfortable with a medium- to long-term purchase horizon.
- You know that your expectations are in line with reality, so you are willing to wait patiently for a great deal to come along.

To an agent, this looks like more work, less reward. Many first-time home buyers and investors who share this mindset are perceived as less valuable, which will be a challenge for you to overcome when searching for the right agent. It's important to understand that asking any real estate agent to put in twice the work for half the pay makes you a less appealing client.

Luckily, you can be prepared to set reasonable expectations for working with a potential agent. For your first meeting with an agent, you should come to the table with much of the information we discussed in Chapter Five—like what type of home you want, what neighborhoods you prefer, and what price range you are realistically expecting to pursue. You should bring some examples of recently sold properties that are in line with your expectations.

Then you should demonstrate that you are prepared (both financially and emotionally) to purchase a property and indicate a high intent to do so. You basically need to prove that while you may be looking at a lower price point with a longer timeline than typical clients, you won't be a waste of time. That's your biggest bargaining chip, since it's more than can be said about most clients—even those with a higher price point.

To prove that you know precisely what you need, you can tell your potential agent the following:

1. You want the agent in a series of preliminary meetings or phone calls to confirm—or give you feedback on—the assumptions you're making for your property purchase. Is your research producing realistic expectations, or do you need to adjust them?
2. You need the agent to set up a search for properties that meet your criteria. Because a good deal doesn't last on the market, you need to be notified immediately when a house within your parameters comes online. The Multiple Listing Service (MLS) is faster and provides more accurate information than free online listing sites, and your agent can provide access to MLS listings.